

Try not to succumb to pressure or feelings of guilt

If you're used to pleasing others at any cost to your own wellbeing, you may feel that you are letting them down, or you may bend under pressure and end up agreeing to something very similar to the thing that you said no to. The other person may feel annoyed with you for putting your boundary in place, but this is very likely to be fleeting. If the relationship is worth maintaining, they will come to understand why your boundary is important. They may also feel that they can find a way round your boundary, by suggesting a 'lighter' version of their original request, but it's important to stay firm if this is still not something that works for you.

Prepare to be consistent

When it comes to creating firm and rooted boundaries, consistency is key. You need to be prepared to repeat this boundary behaviour until other parties understand where that boundary is, and stop trying to step over it. If it helps, create a list of stock phrases that work in different areas – some for work, some for personal relationships – and simply repeat when needed. Having prepared responses helps to remove some of the anxiety and emotion from these exchanges. As you see the positive effects of your new boundaries, it will get easier and more automatic to enforce them.